While van Leeuwenhoek examined water samples, fellow Dutchman Jan Swammerdam was placing insects under his own microscope. He published records of all manner of insects depicted in the finest detail and uncovered much about their anatomy. Swammerdam's most influential work was *Life of the Ephemera* (1675), which recorded in great detail the life cycle of the mayfly.

In England, Nehemiah Grew used microscopy to examine a wide range of plants. He was the first to identify flowers as being the sexual organs of plants. In *The Anatomy of Plants* (1682), Grew named the stamen as the male organ and the pistil as the female organ. Grew also spotted pollen grains and noted that they were transported by bees.

Since the early days of microscopy, devices have grown in sophistication. The electron microscope, first used in 1931, uses beams of electrons—rather than light—to reveal objects, allowing scientists an even closer look. Electron microscopes provide views of up to one million times actual size—600 times greater than most modern light microscopes.